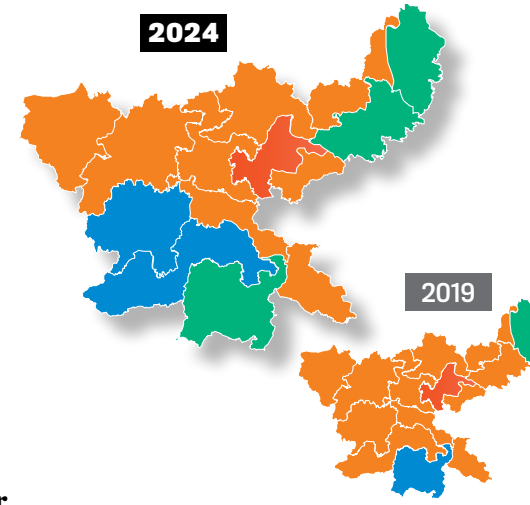
REVENGE OF THE TRIBALS

The NDA may have lost all goodwill among the state's 26 per cent tribals due to ED action against ex-CM Hemant Soren



ANI

THE RISE OF KALPANA SOREN
The JMM leader during election campaigning in Sahibganj in May



TOTAL LOK SABHA SEATS 14

	BJP	AJSU	JMM	CONG
2024	8 (44.6%)	1 (2.6%)	3 (14.6%)	2 (19.2%)
2019	11 (51.61%)	1 (4.39%)	1 (11.66%)	1 (15.83%)

Vote share in ( )

By **Amitabh Srivastava**

Did Jharkhand Mukti Morcha (JMM) leader and former Jharkhand chief minister Hemant Soren's being in custody in an alleged land scam case result in sympathy voting for his party in the just-concluded Lok Sabha election? Yes and no. While the Bharatiya Janata Party-led National Democratic Alliance (NDA) won nine out of Jharkhand's 14 Lok Sabha seats, it lost all five seats reserved for the Scheduled Tribes (STs) in the state, bringing its tally down by three from the 12 seats it had won in the previous election in 2019. The JMM and its allies have projected Hemant's arrest by the Enforcement Directorate (ED) in January as an example of the anti-tribal stance of the ruling BJP at the Centre. On June 4, while the JMM picked three of the ST seats, two were won by ally Congress.

The BJP's reduced tally, and the outcome in the ST-reserved seats will be of some comfort to Kalpana Soren, Hemant's wife, who had emerged as the public face of the JMM since her husband's arrest. The June 4 results also something of a personal victory for her. Hemant's resignation from the post of CM ahead of his arrest on January 31 had left a vacuum in the state's JMM-Congress-Rashtriya Janata Dal government leadership, which Kalpana could not fill owing to objections raised by her sister-in-law Sita Soren on her not being an MLA; Sita was then a JMM legislator. This resulted in 67-year-old Champai Soren being made CM. On June 4, Kalpana also won the Gandey bypoll, held on May 20, by a margin of 27,149 votes. What would likely add an extra edge of sweetness to her victory is Sita's loss from the family's Dumka stronghold—in March, Sita quit the JMM to join the BJP and was fielded as the NDA candidate from the constituency; the June 4 results showed she had lost the seat to JMM's Nalin Soren by a margin of 22,527 votes.

The Lok Sabha election outcomes serve as a critical wake-up call for the BJP in Jharkhand, especially with the state polls scheduled just months from now, says political observer Suman K. Shrivastava. Tribals comprise 26 per cent of Jharkhand's electorate, according to the 2011 Census. The BJP has experienced the influence wielded by the community in the past. In 2019, months after winning the Lok Sabha polls in the state, the party and its allies lost the assembly polls, arguably because of its poor show in ST reserved seats, of which the BJP won only two. It can upset the cohort at its own risk. ■